LIGHTCHAIN

Compute grants to onboard independent AI power and decentralise the network

DAO proposal, draft v4.1 for community discussion. 17 October 2026. A twelve-month grant programme funded by the Lightchain AI Foundation. The DAO Treasury spends nothing.

Why now

Lightchain runs a working verified-inference network, but almost all of it is the Foundation's own hardware. Of the 13 workers online, 9 are Foundation machines. Of the 69 validators, 66 are. Over the last six weeks the Foundation did 89% of all jobs. Four independent workers are online and none can cover a GPU on today's fees: an 8B answer pays 0.02 LCAI, about two thousandths of a cent, a price set when LCAI was seven times higher.

The network cannot become decentralised if nobody outside the Foundation can afford to run it. This proposal is a grant programme to onboard independent GPU power and validators, make running them economically viable while demand builds, fund it without touching the Treasury, and reprice inference so the grants end on their own as fees take over.

What we propose

- **Monthly compute grants for independent operators.** Workers receive a grant floor for the model class they actually serve: small $150, medium $400, large $1,000, XL $3,000 a month. Independent validators $70 against a $50 server. The grant covers only the gap between the floor and the fees an operator earned, so every paid job shrinks it and fees replace grants as the network grows. Half is paid monthly, half is locked six months then vests.
- **Work, not registration.** To qualify in a month a worker needs at least 30 released undisputed jobs in its tier, a stake equal to one month of its grant floor (150,000 to 3,000,000 LCAI, refundable), 95% uptime, and every replay check passed. The five independent workers with a track record are grandfathered. 17 slots open: 9 small, 3 medium, 3 large, 2 XL.
- **The Foundation is excluded and pays.** Foundation workers, validators and agents earn nothing. The Foundation funds the programme for twelve months, up to 13.5M LCAI a month worst case, through the DUNA Clearing House Safe. Realistic first-month cost is under 1M LCAI.
- **Fees priced from what the product is worth.** A Lightchain job is an escrowed, replayable, disputable answer with a receipt. Fees become dollar-anchored and linear in output tokens: small $0.003, medium $0.009, large $0.018, planning $0.060 per typical 400-token job, settled in LCAI. Raised in three monthly steps from 1 December to 1 February. Chat users keep their free allowance.
- **Every funded worker is verified.** Replay sampling goes to 100% on adoption, weekly probe prompts from rotating wallets check every independent worker, and tiers are payable only for models the disputer can replay. Disputer coverage of every model, an official worker image and peer verification follow on dated deliverables.
- **Demand is named.** Autonomous agents at agents.us.org, each with a wallet, a verifiable mailbox and endpoints, sold on plans from $15 to $150 a month, with the inference share settled through the protocol. About 350 paying independent agents bring the grants to zero once paid agent traffic is routed to grant holders first. Bounties go to the first independent hosts of models that run on one machine today.
- **Governance catches up.** Protocol contracts move under the DAO Timelock by 30 November. The Foundation leaves the validator fee pool so fees flow to independents. A small gas floor so block space is not free. The agents.us.org domain is owned by the DUNA and operated by the Foundation under a revocable licence.

The numbers

	Small	Medium	Large	XL	Validator
Grant floor a month	$150	$400	$1,000	$3,000	$70
Covers	home GPU or L4	4090 or 5090	A100 or RTX PRO 6000	2 to 4 x 80 GB	4 vCPU server
Slot stake (LCAI)	150,000	400,000	1,000,000	3,000,000	500,000 deposit
Slots	9	3	3	2	up to 10
Fee per typical job	$0.003	$0.009	$0.018	$0.060	5% fee share
Jobs a day to live on fees alone	about 2,100	about 1,850	about 2,300	about 2,100	n/a

Worst case, every slot filled and no fees earned: about 13.1M LCAI a month, about $13,000 at $0.00099, 157M LCAI over the year. Today 4 of 17 slots would be filled, all small tier, for about 820,000 LCAI in month one. Half of every grant is locked, so liquid flow at full slots is about 6.5M LCAI a month, 1.3% of current monthly DEX volume.

What the DAO votes on

Vote	Decision
1	Ratify the compute grants programme: tiers, qualifying rules, exclusion list, lock, bounties, verification, agent demand plan, mail layer design, dated deliverables.
1a	Foundation validators leave the fee distributor list, and the validator path to 30 independents.
2	Adopt the dollar-anchored fee function and the three-step ramp.
3	0.05 gwei gas floor and a liveness condition for job assignment, in the next releases.
4	Hand AIConfig, JobRegistry, WorkerRegistry and FeePool to the Timelock by 30 November 2026.
5	Deliver per-token metering and a bounded fee keeper as upgrades by 31 March 2027.

No vote moves Treasury funds. Proposal threshold 140,000 LCAI, voting about five days, quorum 3%, Timelock 48 hours. First grants for November land in the first week of December.

Timeline

When	What ships
Before posting	Replay sampling to 100%; retroactive check of grandfathered workers; eligibility script published; hourly heartbeat logging running from 1 November.
1 December 2026	First fee step; probe prompts live; November eligibility list posted five days before payment.
31 January 2027	Disputer covers every model; dispute slashing back on; agent registry and names; domain under the DUNA.
31 March 2027	Official worker image; agents.us.org gateway and mailbox with the Foundation as first operator; mainnet per-call API and grant-holders-first dispatch with the metering upgrade; reservations as an off-chain pilot.
30 June to 30 September 2027	Open mail operator role and relays; on-chain reservations; peer verification; agent-owned domains; agent-to-agent calls. Programme review at month twelve.

How to check the numbers

Everything here is measured from chain 9200 at block 3,058,217 and from public endpoints. The eligibility script, probe runner and every monthly list live in the public repository lightchain-protocol/lightchain-operator-program, so anyone can reproduce who receives a grant. The full draft with every rule, formula and source is published alongside this summary.

Tell us where you disagree. The thread is open for seven days, then the proposal goes to a vote.